How aggregation can conceal composition: aggregate biocapacity and the identifiability of modelled ecological-capital drawdown

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Abstract

Total biocapacity, the headline index of annual bioproductive supply, is a single number assembled from heterogeneous land accounts whose yields and regeneration rates differ by an order of magnitude. We ask what such an aggregate can and cannot reveal about the land it summarises. We formulate a minimal two-land delay-differential model in which demand in excess of the harvestable flow converts ecological-capital land into fast-provisioning land, with area conserved one-to-one, capital quality carried as a separate state, and degradation acting through an accumulated ecological debt. Three results are proved and verified numerically. (i) Conversion raises the measured aggregate while the capital book falls whenever the fast-land yield exceeds the per-hectare value of capital land (a composition mask), and the aggregate alone cannot distinguish this from genuine growth: with only the total, the capital loss is unidentified. (ii) Under frozen demand the balance point is unique and the capital book is driven to its viability floor above a demand ceiling ($E_{\mathrm{ceil}} \approx 1.14$ at the baseline); because the deficit-side dynamics are affine, the leading eigenvalue ($-0.054\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$) is constant along the branch, so the drawdown is a floor collision without a fold, without hysteresis and without critical slowing down; with endogenous demand the drawdown depth is a continuous function of initial demand. (iii) The mask is bounded: technology lifts the fast yield by at most a fixed factor, whereas debt erosion is limited only by the sustained deficit. Applied to the National Footprint and Biocapacity Accounts (1961–2022), an exact Divisia decomposition shows that

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aggregate biocapacity grew +23% while cropland biocapacity grew 2.85× and the non-cropland book was flat, and per-capita biocapacity halved. The results motivate component reporting alongside any aggregate biocapacity total.

Keywords: biocapacity, ecological footprint, land-use conversion, aggregation, identifiability, critical slowing down, delay differential equations, carrying capacity

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1. Introduction

Carrying capacity is one of ecology's most enduring and most elusive ideas. In classical population biology it is a fixed ceiling; imported into global human ecology it is usually treated as a static boundary, the maximum number of people the Earth can support (cf. Cohen, 1995). Treating the ceiling as fixed overlooks a feedback that matters: a population that overshoots its resource base degrades the base and lowers the future ceiling. This paper is concerned with a subtler failure than a fixed ceiling. It concerns the *measurement* on which monitoring and policy depend.

The standard aggregate measure of annual regenerative supply is biocapacity, expressed in the National Footprint and Biocapacity Accounts (NFA) in global hectares (gha). A global hectare is already a value-weighted product of bioproductive area, a yield factor and an equivalence factor (Borucke et al., 2013; Lin et al., 2018). Because the weighting sits *inside* the unit, an aggregate biocapacity series does not tell a monitor whether capacity rose because land became more productive, because more land was brought into provision, or because ecological capital was converted into provisioning land. The composite-indicator literature warns that additive aggregation turns weights into trade-offs, so that a deficit in one dimension can be offset by a surplus in another (Nardo et al., 2008; Becker et al., 2017; Fischer et al., 2022); biocapacity is exactly such a composite, and the footprint framework has been criticised on related grounds (Blomqvist et al., 2013; Giampietro and Saltelli, 2014; van den Bergh and Grazi, 2015; Galli et al., 2016). The aggregate remains useful as a headline, but only if its components are reported alongside it. What has been missing is a dynamical account of *how* a rising aggregate and a falling capital base can coexist, for how long, and what would be needed to tell them apart.

Coupled human–environment models have largely treated the environment as a single stock or a single aggregate balance: the World3 system (Meadows et al., 1972, 1974, 2004), the Ricardo–Malthus models of Easter Island (Brander and Taylor, 1998; Anderies, 2000), and more recent bidirectionally coupled Earth-system frameworks (Motesharrei et al., 2016; Donges et al., 2017; Calvin and Bond-Lamberty, 2018; Henderson and Loreau, 2018). Estimates of Earth's carrying capacity span several orders of magnitude (Cohen, 1995; van den Bergh and Rietveld, 2004), some authors reject the notion for humans altogether (Simon, 1996), and others let the ceiling itself vary logistically (Meyer, 1994; Meyer and Ausubel, 1999) or treat natural capital as a depreciating asset (Dasgupta, 2021). Demographic projections used in most global assessments assume that population unfolds independently of environmental constraints (United Nations, 2022). Within this literature the environment has one book; the question of what an aggregate over two books with different yields and regeneration times can conceal has not been posed as a modelling problem, although the land-use literature has documented the historical operator – conversion of forest, grassland and wetland into cropland – in detail (Haberl et al., 2007; Krausmann et al., 2013; Erb et al., 2017).

Consider an orchard with two kinds of ground. Fast provisioning land – cropland and intensively managed systems – yields much and is quickly restored, but has little standing regenerative value. Ecological-capital land – forest, soil, wetland, long-rotation systems – has a large standing value and a regenerative flow that is slowly rebuilt. Demand is met first from the fast flow; only the excess converts capital land into provision. Because the aggregate harvest is a value-weighted sum over the two books, conversion can raise the total while the capital book shrinks. A harvest that looks stable, or a rising aggregate measure of capacity, can therefore mask a shrinking ecological-capital account. Neither the orchard nor its harvesters respond instantly – forest loss, soil degradation and demographic adjustment unfold over decades – which is why societies can prosper for long periods while quietly undermining their productive base, only to decline abruptly (Tainter, 1988; Diamond, 2005). The companion ledger work calls the general phenomenon the *productivity illusion* (Abaee, 2026c); the specific form addressed here is the *composition* illusion, in which the aggregate rises not because technology outpaces degradation but because the books are re-weighted.

We address three questions. **(Q1)** Under what conditions does conversion of ecological-capital land raise the aggregate while the capital book falls,

how long does the mask last, and can the composition be identified from the aggregate? **(Q2)** Is the resulting capital drawdown a catastrophic shift in the sense of the alternative-stable-states literature (Scheffer et al., 2001), with a fold, hysteresis and early-warning signals, or something structurally different? **(Q3)** Is the mask self-limiting, and what does recovery require?

The paper makes four contributions. First, it formulates a minimal two-land model (Section 2) in which area is conserved one-to-one across three land books, per-hectare capital quality is a separate state, conversion is a rate with an explicit time constant, and degradation acts on the surviving yield through an accumulated ecological debt; the model is a delay differential equation with ecological (regeneration) and demographic delays (Kuang, 1993; Hutchinson, 1948). Second, it proves three propositions (Section 3): a composition identity that gives the exact condition for the mask and shows that the aggregate does not identify the capital loss (Proposition 1); the uniqueness of the frozen-demand balance point, the location of the demand ceiling, and the absence of a fold and of critical slowing down, derived from the affine structure of the deficit-side dynamics (Proposition 2); and a boundedness asymmetry between the technology and debt channels that makes the mask transient (Proposition 3). Third, it applies the composition identity to the measured NFA series for 1961–2022 with an exact logarithmic-mean (Divisia) decomposition and the measured land-type accounts (Section 3.5). Fourth, it states the falsifiable content of the model as five predictions and draws the reporting implication for sustainability indicators (Sections 3.6 and 4). The model is deliberately simple and most of its parameters are representative rather than fitted; it is not a forecast. Its purpose is to make the composition logic of aggregate biocapacity explicit and to state which outcomes are structural and which are conditional on effective parameters that are not separately identified.

2. Methods

2.1. A two-land model with conserved area and a separate quality state

The bioproductive area A_{tot} is divided into three books: fast-provisioning land A_f (cropland and intensively managed systems), ecological-capital land A_c (forest, soil, wetland and long-rotation systems, consolidated into one effective class), and a reserve A_r (fallow, retired or not yet allocated land), with $A_f + A_c + A_r = A_{tot}$ at all times. Capital land carries a per-hectare

quality index $q \in [0, q_{\max}]$ (a capacity state, not an area), which regenerates logistically,

$$G_c(q) = \rho_c \, q \left(1 - \frac{q}{q_{\max}}\right), \tag{1}$$

so that the per-hectare value of capital land, in flow units, is

$$\Upsilon_c(q) = b_c + b_{G,c} \, G_c(q), \tag{2}$$

the sum of a direct yield b_c and the value $b_{G,c}$ of the regenerative growth $G_c(q)$. Biocapacity is the additive two-book aggregate

$$B = Y_f + Y_c = b_f A_f + \Upsilon_c(q) \, A_c, \tag{3}$$

in gha yr^{-1}. Demand is the footprint $E = eP$ of a population P with constant per-capita footprint e, and the shortfall above the human-available flow is

$$S = \left[E - \sigma_f Y_f - \sigma_c Y_c\right]_+, \tag{4}$$

with $[x]_+ = \max(x, 0)$ exact (never smoothed) and $\sigma_f = \sigma_c = 1$ in the baseline. The shortfall is closed by converting capital land into fast land at a finite rate,

$$u_c = \frac{1}{\tau_{\mathrm{conv}}} \min\left(\frac{S}{b_f}, \; A_c - A_c^{\min}\right) \qquad [\mathrm{ha}\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}], \tag{5}$$

where S/b_f is the area that would close the shortfall at the fast-land yield, $A_c^{\min}$ is a typed viability floor, and τ_{conv} is the conversion time constant. The land books evolve by one-to-one area transfers only,

$$\dot{A}_c = -u_c + R_{rc}, \tag{6}$$

$$\dot{A}_f = u_c + \mu A_r - \eta_f A_f, \tag{7}$$

$$\dot{A}_r = -\mu A_r + \eta_f A_f - R_{rc}, \tag{8}$$

where μA_r is cropland maintenance (replanting from the reserve), $\eta_f A_f$ is fast-land retirement to the reserve, and R_{rc} is an explicit, surplus-gated restoration flow from reserve to capital land,

$$R_{rc} = \chi_r \, A_r \, \left[B - E\right]_+, \tag{9}$$

which is the only route back into the capital book. Equations (6)–(8) sum to zero, so the reserve is a constrained balance rather than an independent

state. Quality regenerates with a recruitment delay, population follows a delayed logistic law (Pearl, 1925; Hutchinson, 1948) on the carrying capacity $K = B/e$, and degradation acts on the surviving fast-land yield through an accumulated ecological debt D:

$$\dot{q} = G_c\big(q(t-\tau_g)\big), \tag{10}$$

$$\dot{P} = rP\left(1 - \frac{P}{K(t-\tau_p)}\right), \qquad K = \max(B/e,\, K_{\min}), \tag{11}$$

$$b_f = \big(b_{f0} + T_b(t)\big)\, e^{-\alpha D}, \tag{12}$$

$$\dot{D} = [E - B]_+ - \eta D, \tag{13}$$

$$T_b(t) = \frac{\Delta b}{1 + e^{-\kappa_w (t - t_{wave})}}. \tag{14}$$

The technology wave T_b is a bounded logistic yield step (off unless stated). The state is (A_f, A_c, q, P, D) with one delay each in regeneration and demography; a timber-liquidation channel and a direct fast-to-capital restoration flow are stated extensions that are off in every reported run (Supplementary Information, SI §S1).

Five conventions are essential. (i) *The positive part is exact.* A smoothed ramp would leak conversion when $E < B$; the one-sided deficit mechanism is the model's content, so $[\cdot]_+$ is never regularised and stability at $S = 0$ is one-sided. (ii) *Conversion is a rate.* S/b_f is a stock (ha); it becomes a rate only through τ_{conv}, so u_c is dimensionally $\text{ha}\,\text{yr}^{-1}$ and conversion is never instantaneous. (iii) *Area is conserved one-to-one and capacity is a separate book.* Every area flow in (6)–(8) moves hectares between books; regeneration G_c is a flow of capacity into q and never transfers land, so conservation is a property of the equations, not an identity imposed afterwards. (iv) *Flows and stocks are never interchanged.* B and E are annual flows ($\text{gha}\,\text{yr}^{-1}$); D is the accumulation of a flow (gha) repaid at rate η; b_f, b_c are flow yields and $b_{G,c}$ is a standing value. (v) *A sustainable cropland equilibrium exists.* Because (7) contains the maintenance term μA_r, a positive fast book A_f^* is sustained without conversion; without it the fast book would decay to zero at every equilibrium.

Two positive feedback loops act on different books. The *conversion loop* reallocates area: $A_c \downarrow \to A_f \uparrow \to B \uparrow$ (if $b_f > \Upsilon_c$) $\to K \uparrow \to P \uparrow \to S \uparrow \to A_c \downarrow$; it raises the aggregate while the capital book falls and is the composition mechanism of this paper. The *debt loop* erodes the surviving yield: $D \uparrow \to$

$b_f \downarrow\!\rightarrow B \downarrow\!\rightarrow S \uparrow\!\rightarrow D \uparrow$; it later turns against the aggregate and is one reason the mask is bounded (Proposition 3).

2.2. Parameters and their status

Table 1 lists the baseline registry. The capital book is a strategic reduction: real ecological capital is a vector of land types with their own yields, values and regeneration times, and the two-book model treats them as one effective class. Consequently most parameters are representative, effective quantities rather than estimates, and the results are stated with that status attached. Two quantities are empirically anchored: the capital-land regeneration timescale, which we bound from raw recovery curves in two ecosystem classes (secondary forest, Poorter et al., 2016; collapsed fish stocks, RAM Legacy, cf. Hutchings and Reynolds, 2004; Neubauer et al., 2013; with soil organic carbon, Poeplau et al., 2011, between them; SI §S5.5), and the provisioning-book yield and area, which we calibrate against NFA cropland biocapacity and the FAO crop-yield index (SI §S5.3). The regeneration anchors bound a *band* of effective timescales (≈25–33 yr, representative ≈29 yr; forest $t_{50} \approx 30$ yr, fishery $t_{50} \approx 5.6$ yr) and are statements about the regeneration rate, not the lag τ_g; the two are kept distinct throughout. The baseline sits in the composition-premium regime, $\Delta b_{\mathrm{conv}} = b_f - \Upsilon_c(q) > 0$, which is the regime in which the mask is possible (Section 3.1); Table 1 therefore fixes a regime, not a prediction.

2.3. Data and the observation operator

The empirical analysis uses the world series of the National Footprint and Biocapacity Accounts (2025 edition): the aggregate biocapacity and footprint series for 1961–2022, and the land-type biocapacity matrix (cropland, grazing land, forest products, fishing grounds, built-up land). The land-type vintage incorporates a retroactive re-basing and gives a slightly higher aggregate growth (+24.5%, $\Delta \ln B = +0.219$) than the aggregate series (+23.0%, $\Delta \ln B = +0.207$); rather than blend the vintages we report the attribution across both (SI §S5.2). Population is from the same accounts. The independent proxies that advance past the aggregate are FAOSTAT cropland area (arable plus permanent crops) for A_f and a normalised FAO crop-yield index for b_f, calibrated at the base year either by a nominal cropland share α of 1961 biocapacity or directly against measured NFA cropland biocapacity (FAO, 2023); forest area (FAO, 2020), historical land-use reconstructions (Hurtt et al., 2011; Klein Goldewijk et al., 2017), remote-sensing land cover

Table 1: Baseline parameter registry (single source of truth for all reported runs) and the status of each parameter. "Representative" values are effective, lumped quantities that are not individually identified; "anchored" values are bounded by independent data (SI §S5); "extension" parameters are stated but off in the base model. Full symbol table with units in SI §S1.

Parameter	Value	Meaning	Status
ρ_c	$0.08\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	quality regeneration rate of capital land	representative; timescale band anchored
b_{f0}	$0.85\,\mathrm{gha\,ha}^{-1}\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	base fast-land flow yield	representative (NFA cropland book ≈ 0.93 in 1961)
b_c	$0.05\,\mathrm{gha\,ha}^{-1}\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	capital-land direct yield	representative
$b_{G,c}$	$0.8\,\mathrm{gha\,ha}^{-1}$	standing value of one hectare of capital	representative
$q_{\max}$	1.0	quality ceiling	normalisation
μ	$0.06\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	cropland maintenance (reserve→fast)	representative
η_f	$0.05\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	fast-land retirement (fast→reserve)	representative
τ_{conv}	1.0 yr	conversion time constant	representative
α	$0.03\,\mathrm{gha}^{-1}$	degradation of b_f per unit debt	representative
η	$0.05\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	debt-repayment rate (> 0)	representative
e	$0.55\,\mathrm{gha\,cap}^{-1}\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	per-capita footprint (constant)	representative
r	$0.02\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$	intrinsic population growth	representative
$\tau_g,\ \tau_p$	20, 25 yr	regeneration and demographic delays	representative; τ_p lumps institutional lags
A_{tot}	2.5 ha	total bioproductive area	normalisation
$\sigma_f,\ \sigma_c$	1, 1	human-available flow shares	baseline (< 1: reservation extension)
χ_r	$0.10\,\mathrm{gha}^{-1}$	surplus-gated restoration coefficient	on with endogenous demand; off under frozen demand
$A_c^{\min}$, $A_r^{\min}$, $K_{\min}$	0.05 ha, 0.10 ha, 0.02 cap	typed floors	domain constraints
Δb, κ_w, t_{wave}	1.0, $0.1\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$, 40 yr	technology wave	extension; off in all reported runs

(ESA, 2017; Copernicus, 2019) and cropland-productivity maps (Monfreda et al., 2008) form the hierarchy of extensions described in SI §S5.4.

The decomposition instrument is the exact logarithmic-mean (Divisia) identity. Writing $B_t = X_t + C_t$ with a proxy fast-book component $X_t = \hat{b}_{f,t} A_{f,t}$ and residual $C_t = B_t - X_t$,

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta \ln B &= w_X \big(\Delta \ln b_f + \Delta \ln A_f\big) + w_C \, \Delta \ln C, \\ w_X &= \frac{L(X_T, X_0)}{L(B_T, B_0)}, \qquad w_C = \frac{L(C_T, C_0)}{L(B_T, B_0)}, \end{aligned} \tag{15}$$

with the logarithmic mean $L(a,b) = (a-b)/(\ln a - \ln b)$ for $a \neq b$ and $L(a,a) = a$. The identity holds exactly whenever X and C are positive at both endpoints; average-share weights do not (they overshoot by $\approx 11\%$ here), and the level decomposition $\Delta B = \Delta X + \Delta C$ is the exact fallback when the residual is not positive (SI §S5.2). The extensive/intensive split uses the exact identity $d \ln B = d \ln(B/P) + d \ln P$.

2.4. Numerical solution and verification

The delay system is integrated by the method of steps with an explicit first-order scheme ($\Delta t = 0.05$ yr for the demonstration run, 0.1 and 0.05 yr for the drawdown sweeps), the exact positive part, clamps enforcing $A_c \geq A_c^{\min}$, $A_f \geq 0$, $q \in [0, q_{\max}]$, $K \geq K_{\min}$, and delay histories populated with the initial state rather than zero (a zero history produces spurious early collapses). Area conservation is verified at every step ($\max |A_f + A_c + A_r - A_{tot}| = 2.2 \times 10^{-16}$). Every analytic quantity below (balance points, ceiling, eigenvalues, composition diagnostic) is recomputed from the deposited code and asserted against the stated value before a figure is written. Drawdown thresholds are reported as bands because the operational floor-contact criterion depends on the tolerance and step size (Section 3.2). The deposited solver evaluates the regeneration term of (10) at the current rather than the delayed quality; because q is monotone and the regenerative term is small at the baseline ($b_{G,c} G_c \leq 0.016$ against $b_c = 0.05$), applying the delay changes the reported quantities by less than 1% (window 149 vs. 150 yr; thresholds within 0.001), and both variants are reported in SI §S3. Code and data are deposited (Zenodo record 22554480).

3. Results

3.1. The composition mask and what the aggregate cannot identify

The per-hectare value of capital land $\Upsilon_c(q)$ is a concave quadratic in q with an interior maximum at $q^* = q_{\max}/2$, where $\Upsilon_c(q^*) = b_c + b_{G,c}\rho_c q_{\max}/4 = 0.066$ at the baseline; the regenerative term there (0.016) is about one third of the direct yield (0.05; ratio 0.32), so capital value is only modestly enhanced by regeneration. The quantity that governs what conversion does to the aggregate is the *composition diagnostic*

$$\Delta b_{\text{conv}}(q, D) = b_f(D) - \Upsilon_c(q), \tag{16}$$

the difference between what a hectare yields in the fast book and what it is worth in the capital book. At the baseline $\Delta b_{\text{conv}} = +0.787,\ +0.784,\ +0.794$ at $q = 0.3, 0.6, 0.9$: the model sits robustly in the composition-premium regime, in which converting a hectare raises current accounting capacity. The three regimes $\Delta b_{\text{conv}} > 0$ (premium: conversion raises B, mask possible), $\Delta b_{\text{conv}} = 0$ (first-order neutrality, non-generic) and $\Delta b_{\text{conv}} < 0$ (discount: conversion lowers B at once, no mask) are the only shape distinction the quality-based model admits; because Y_c is linear in A_c at fixed q, there is no area-based capacity maximum and no regime split of the kind an area-based regeneration law would produce.

Proposition 1 (Composition identity, mask and non-identifiability)**.** *Let $T_b \equiv 0$, $R_{rc} \equiv 0$ and hold D fixed, so that b_f is constant. Along any solution of (3)–(10),*

$$\dot{B} = \Delta b_{\text{conv}}(q)\, u_c + b_f\big(\mu A_r - \eta_f A_f\big) + b_{G,c}\, G_c'(q)\, A_c\, \dot{q}. \tag{17}$$

(i) On any interval on which $u_c > 0$, $\dot{A}_c < 0$, and the conversion contribution to $\dot{B}$ is positive if and only if $\Delta b_{\text{conv}}(q) > 0$. In the pure-conversion subsystem ($\mu A_r = \eta_f A_f$, $q = q_{\max}$), $\dot{B} > 0 \iff \Delta b_{\text{conv}} > 0$ whenever $u_c > 0$: the aggregate rises while the capital book falls.

(ii) Under frozen demand E and $\Delta b_{\text{conv}} > 0$, the shortfall S is strictly decreasing along pure conversion ($\dot{S} = -\dot{B} < 0$ on $S > 0$), so the mask is a transient: the trajectory converges to a state with $S = 0$ (the balance point of Proposition 2) or with $A_c = A_c^{\min}$.

(iii) The aggregate (3) is one linear functional of the two areas. From the series $B(t)$ alone, any observed change $\Delta B \geq 0$ is consistent with every capital change $\Delta A_c \in [A_c^{\min} - A_c(0),\, 0]$ (the fast-book change $\Delta A_f = (\Delta B - \Upsilon_c \Delta A_c)/b_f$ absorbs the difference); the capital loss is unidentified. If b_f and A_f are observed independently, the residual $C = B - b_f A_f = \Upsilon_c(q) A_c$ identifies the product $\Upsilon_c(q) A_c$, but b_c, $b_{G,c}$, ρ_c and q enter only through $\Upsilon_c = b_c + b_{G,c}\rho_c q(1 - q/q_{\max})$ and are not separately identifiable from C; the identifiable combinations are Υ_c (equivalently $b_{c,\text{eff}}$) and $b_{G,c}\rho_c$.

Proof. Differentiate (3) with b_f constant and substitute (6)–(7) with $R_{rc} = 0$: $\dot{B} = b_f(u_c + \mu A_r - \eta_f A_f) - \Upsilon_c u_c + b_{G,c} G_c'(q) A_c \dot{q}$, which is (17). (i) is immediate from (17) and $\dot{A}_c = -u_c$. (ii) With $\sigma_f = \sigma_c = 1$ and $S > 0$, $S = E - B$, so $\dot{S} = -\dot{B} = -\Delta b_{\text{conv}} u_c < 0$; S is bounded below by zero and A_c is non-increasing and bounded below by $A_c^{\min}$, so the trajectory converges to a state with $S = 0$ or $A_c = A_c^{\min}$. (iii) is the statement that a single linear equation in two unknowns has a one-parameter family of solutions, and that Υ_c depends on $(b_c, b_{G,c}, \rho_c, q)$ only through the stated combination. □

Figure 1a shows the mask at the baseline under frozen demand $E = 0.825$ (restoration off, $A_{f0} = 0.6$, $A_{c0} = 1.5$, $q_0 = 0.9$, $A_r(0) = 0.4$). Biocapacity rises from 0.594 to 0.825 (+39%) while capital land falls from 1.500 to 0.808 (−46%) and fast land rises from 0.600 to 0.923; quality rises from 0.9 to 1.0, so the capital *quality* is not drawn down even as its *area* is. The area changes are one-to-one ($\Delta A_f + \Delta A_c + \Delta A_r = 0$ to machine precision). The dynamics are fast at first and then asymptotic: because the deficit-side land subsystem is affine (Proposition 2(ii)), the approach to the balance point is exponential at the slow rate $|\lambda_1| = 0.054\,\text{yr}^{-1}$ (e-folding $\approx 19\,\text{yr}$), so within 25 yr 98% of the rise in B and 85% of the fall in A_c have occurred ($B = 0.820$, $A_c = 0.913$; 97% of the fall by 50 yr), while the strict inequalities $\dot{B} > 0$ and $\dot{A}_c < 0$ persist for $\approx 150\,\text{yr}$ at numerical resolution. The slow tail is reserve equilibration: retirement of fast land to the reserve lowers the fast flow, re-opens a small shortfall, and converts a little more capital, until the reserve reaches its equilibrium share $A_r/A_f = \eta_f/\mu$. The window is therefore not a fixed horizon: its scale is set by λ_1, which depends on τ_{conv}, μ, η_f and the yield ratio b_c/b_f (SI §S2.2), and its amplitude by Δb_{conv} and the initial deficit.

Two consequences of Proposition 1(iii) frame the empirical analysis of Section 3.5. First, the composition signature (B rises while A_c falls) is contem-

poraneously observable only in the two-book series; a monitor who sees the aggregate alone cannot distinguish a composition mask from broad growth. Second, independent proxies for the fast book (A_f, b_f) convert the aggregate into a measured fast book and a residual, which is the most that can be identified without independent ecological valuation of the capital book. We refer to the two readings as the *composition mask* (B rises while A_c falls; requires $\Delta b_{\text{conv}} > 0$) and the *liquidation mask* (E steady while A_c falls; requires nothing); which of the two holds is itself a discriminating observable.

3.2. The drawdown is a demand-driven floor collision, not a fold

With endogenous population there is no interior steady state with active conversion: at a demographic equilibrium $P = K = B/e$, so $E = B$ and $S = 0$. Conversion is therefore a transient regime, and its steady states exist only under a frozen exogenous demand pinned above the flow. The frozen-demand system is where the question of a catastrophic shift must be posed, and it has a complete answer.

Proposition 2 (Balance point, demand ceiling and affine deficit-side dynamics)**.** *Assume frozen demand E, $T_b \equiv 0$, $R_{rc} \equiv 0$, $q = q_{\max}$ (the attractor of (10) for $q(0) > 0$) and $D = 0$. Let $k = \mu/(\mu + \eta_f)$ and*

$$B_{eq}(A_c) = b_{f0}\, k\, (A_{tot} - A_c) + b_c A_c = b_{f0} k A_{tot} - (b_{f0} k - b_c) A_c. \tag{18}$$

(i) Equilibria of the land subsystem on the no-conversion face $S = 0$ satisfy $A_f = k(A_{tot} - A_c)$, $A_r = (1 - k)(A_{tot} - A_c)$ and $B_{eq}(A_c) \geq E$. If $b_{f0} k > b_c$, B_{eq} is strictly decreasing, so the balance point $B_{eq}(A_c^*) = E$ is unique,

$$A_c^*(E) = \frac{b_{f0} k A_{tot} - E}{b_{f0} k - b_c}, \tag{19}$$

and it lies above the typed floor if and only if $E < E_{\text{ceil}} := B_{eq}(A_c^{\min})$.

(ii) On the deficit side ($S > 0$, $S/b_f < A_c - A_c^{\min}$) the land subsystem is affine in $z = (A_f, A_c)$, $\dot{z} = Jz + c$, with

$$J = \begin{pmatrix} -\tau_{\text{conv}}^{-1} - \mu - \eta_f & -\mu - \dfrac{b_c}{b_f \tau_{\text{conv}}} \\ \tau_{\text{conv}}^{-1} & \dfrac{b_c}{b_f \tau_{\text{conv}}} \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \det J = \frac{\mu + \eta_f}{\tau_{\text{conv}}} \Big(k - \frac{b_c}{b_f} \Big), \tag{20}$$

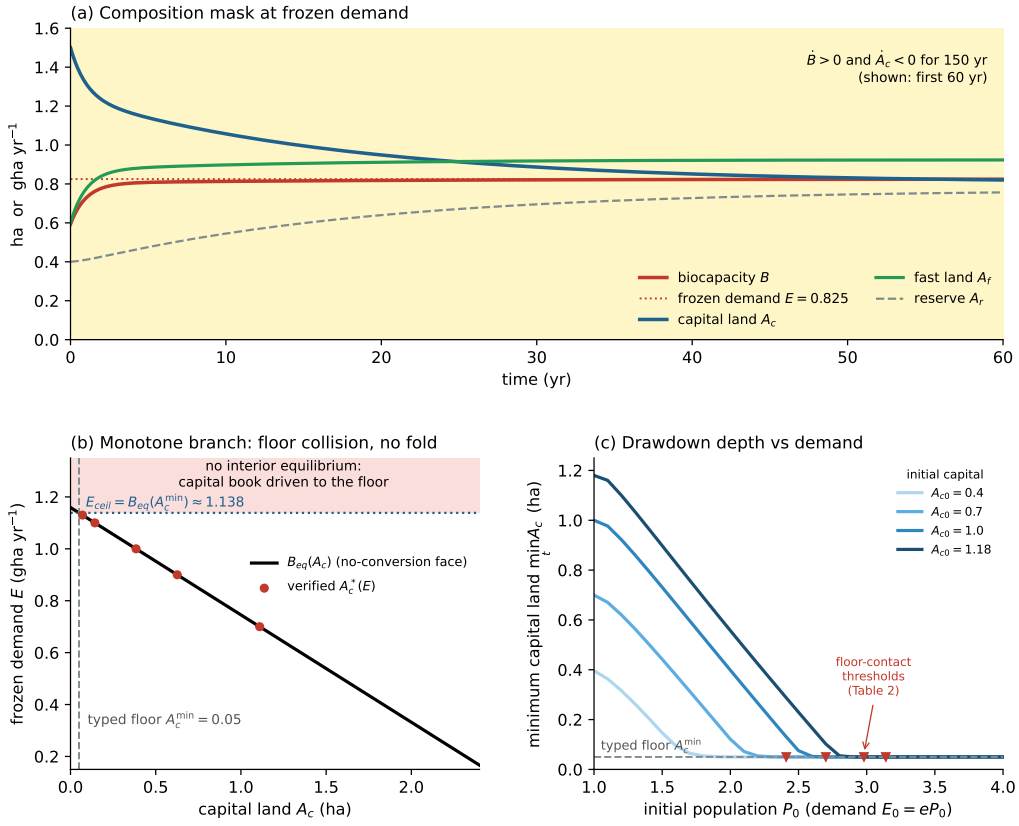


Figure 1: Model dynamics at the baseline registry (Table 1), regenerated from the deposited code. (a) Composition mask under frozen demand $E = 0.825$ (restoration off, $A_{f0} = 0.6$, $A_{c0} = 1.5$, $q_0 = 0.9$): biocapacity B rises from 0.594 to 0.825 while capital land A_c falls from 1.500 to 0.808 and fast land A_f rises from 0.600 to 0.923; the shaded region marks the interval on which $\dot{B} > 0$ and $\dot{A}_c < 0$ hold simultaneously (≈ 150 yr at numerical resolution; only the first 60 yr are shown; 98% of the rise in B and 85% of the fall in A_c occur within the first 25 yr). (b) The frozen-demand balance branch $B_{eq}(A_c)$ of Proposition 2, strictly decreasing in A_c, with the verified balance points $A_c^*(E) = 1.110, 0.626, 0.385, 0.143, 0.070$ at $E = 0.70, 0.90, 1.00, 1.10, 1.13$; the branch meets the typed floor $A_c^{\min} = 0.05$ at the demand ceiling $E_{\text{ceil}} \approx 1.138$, above which no balance point exists and the capital book is driven to the floor (shaded). (c) Endogenous-demand runs ($\tau_g = 20$, $\tau_p = 25$ yr, $\chi_r = 0.10$): the minimum capital land reached during a run is a continuous, monotone function of initial demand P_0 (hence $E_0 = eP_0$) for each initial capital A_{c0}; the floor is approached asymptotically, and the floor-contact thresholds of Table 2 (triangles) are the operational points at which the floor is reached to within 10^{-6}. There is no discontinuity in the outcome as a function of demand.

and $\operatorname{tr} J < 0$. *J does not depend on E or on the state,* $\det J > 0$ *exactly when B_{eq} is decreasing, and the fixed point of the affine system is the balance point of (i). For $E < E_{\mathrm{ceil}}$ the balance point is admissible and every trajectory that remains in this regime converges to it at the constant rates given by the eigenvalues of J; for $E > E_{\mathrm{ceil}}$ the fixed point lies below the floor, the trajectory reaches the face $A_c = A_c^{\min}$ and remains there with a persistent shortfall $S^* = E - E_{\mathrm{ceil}} > 0$. The ceiling is a collision of the equilibrium with a face of the admissible set, not a bifurcation of the vector field: there is no second branch, no fold, no hysteresis, and the leading eigenvalue does not tend to zero as $E \to E_{\mathrm{ceil}}$.*

(iii) Beyond the ceiling, with degradation active, the debt converges to the unique root $D^*(E)$ of $\eta D = E - B_{eq}(A_c^{\min}; D)$, where $B_{eq}(\cdot\,; D)$ uses $b_{f0}e^{-\alpha D}$, provided $\eta > \alpha b_{f0} k (A_{tot} - A_c^{\min})$; D^* is increasing in E.

Proof. (i) With $S = 0$ and $R_{rc} = 0$, (7) gives $\mu A_r = \eta_f A_f$, hence $A_r/A_f = \eta_f/\mu$ and, with $A_r = A_{tot} - A_f - A_c$, $A_f = k(A_{tot} - A_c)$; substituting into (3) with $q = q_{\max}$ ($\Upsilon_c = b_c$) and $D = 0$ gives $B = B_{eq}(A_c)$, and $S = 0$ requires $B \geq E$. Strict monotonicity and (19) follow from $b_{f0}k > b_c$. (ii) On the deficit side $u_c = (E - b_f A_f - b_c A_c)/(b_f \tau_{\mathrm{conv}})$ is affine in z; substituting into (6)–(7) with $A_r = A_{tot} - A_f - A_c$ gives J and a constant vector c by direct differentiation; $\det J$ follows by expansion, and $\operatorname{tr} J = -\tau_{\mathrm{conv}}^{-1}(1 - b_c/b_f) - \mu - \eta_f < 0$ for $b_c < b_f$. The fixed point solves $u_c = 0$ and $\mu A_r = \eta_f A_f$, i.e. it is the balance point. Because J is constant, convergence rates are constant along the branch. (iii) The map $D \mapsto \eta D + B_{eq}(A_c^{\min}; D) - E$ is continuous, negative at $D = 0$ when $E > E_{\mathrm{ceil}}$, tends to $+\infty$, and is strictly increasing when $\eta > \alpha b_{f0} k (A_{tot} - A_c^{\min}) \geq -\partial_D B_{eq}$; hence it has a unique root, which increases with E. □

At the baseline $k = 0.5455$, the slope $b_{f0}k - b_c = 0.414$, and $E_{\mathrm{ceil}} = 1.138$; the balance points $A_c^*(E) = 1.110, 0.626, 0.385, 0.143, 0.070$ at $E = 0.70, 0.90, 1.00, 1.10, 1.13$ agree with the integrated equilibria (Fig. 1b). The eigenvalues of J are real and negative, $\lambda_1 = -0.0537$ and $\lambda_2 = -0.998\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$; λ_1 varies only weakly with the fast-land yield, from -0.0522 at $b_f = 0.60$ to -0.0556 at $b_f = 2.00$ (Table 2a), and never changes sign. There is no universal scalar stability index: the conversion-loop gain is the state- and parameter-dependent Δb_{conv}, of order $1\,\mathrm{gha\,ha}^{-1}\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$, and the return rate is $|\lambda_1|$ of order $10^{-2}\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$. Beyond the ceiling the debt fixed points are $D^* =$

1.19 and 5.38 at $E = 1.158$ and 1.238 (integrated values 1.21 and 5.39); the monotonicity condition of (iii) holds with margin ($\alpha b_{f0} k(A_{tot} - A_c^{\min}) = 0.034 < \eta = 0.05$), so under frozen demand the debt saturates rather than running away.

The statement "no critical slowing down" is precise here. By critical slowing down we mean that the least-negative eigenvalue of the relevant linearisation tends to 0^- as a parameter approaches a fold, so that the return time $T_{ret} \approx -1/\lambda_1$ diverges. In Proposition 2 the linearisation is constant along the entire branch, so neither λ_1 nor $T_{ret} \approx 19\,\text{yr}$ changes as $E \to E_{\text{ceil}}$. The only early-warning signal the model offers is a *boundary* signal, the capital book approaching its typed floor, which is observable only in the two-book series.

With endogenous demand the same structure appears as a continuous drawdown. Figure 1c shows the minimum capital land reached during a run as a function of initial population P_0 for four initial capital stocks: the curves are continuous and monotone, the floor is approached asymptotically (because $u_c \leq (A_c - A_c^{\min})/\tau_{\text{conv}}$, the distance to the floor decays exponentially during a sustained deficit and is never crossed), and higher initial capital supports higher demand before the floor is reached. The "collapse thresholds" of the earlier literature on this model are therefore operational quantities: Table 2b reports the initial demand at which the floor is approached to within 10^{-2}, 10^{-4} and 10^{-6} of its value. The 10^{-6} floor-contact values ($P_0 \approx$ 2.41, 2.70, 2.98, 3.14 for $A_{c0} = 0.40$, 0.70, 1.00, 1.18) are the ones a bisection on exact floor contact returns; they rise monotonically with initial capital, as do the looser criteria, and no criterion exhibits a jump. Two robustness checks bear on the predictions of Section 3.6: the floor-contact threshold at $A_{c0} = 1.0$ is identical to three decimals for $\tau_g = 5$, 20 and 40 yr, and identical to three decimals with the restoration coefficient $\chi_r = 0.10$ and $\chi_r = 0$ (SI §S4). The first reflects the small leverage of the regenerative term at the baseline and the monotone quality dynamics; the second reflects the fact that a surplus-gated flow is inert during the shortfall that produces the drawdown.

3.3. The mask is bounded: technology saturates, debt does not

Both the technology wave and the degradation act on the same coefficient, the fast-land yield b_f of (12), and they do so multiplicatively. This yields a structural asymmetry.

Table 2: Model results at the baseline registry. (a) Composition diagnostic at $q^* = q_{\max}/2$ ($\Upsilon_c(q^*) = 0.066$), eigenvalues of the deficit-side matrix J of (20) and the demand ceiling, for a sweep of the fast-land yield b_f (all other parameters at baseline). (b) Initial demand P_0 (initial footprint $E_0 = 0.55P_0$) at which the minimum capital land reached during an endogenous-demand run ($A_{f0} = 0.6$, $q_0 = 0.9$, $\tau_g = 20$, $\tau_p = 25\,\mathrm{yr}$) comes within the stated distance of the typed floor $A_c^{\min} = 0.05$; the first two columns are read from a P_0 grid of step 0.1 ($\Delta t = 0.1\,\mathrm{yr}$, $T = 400\,\mathrm{yr}$), the last is a bisection on exact floor contact ($\Delta t = 0.05\,\mathrm{yr}$, $T = 1000\,\mathrm{yr}$). Drawdown depth is continuous in P_0 (Fig. 1c); the thresholds are a band, not a single value.

(a) Fast-land yield sweep (all rows composition-premium, $\Delta b_{\mathrm{conv}} > 0$)

b_f	$\Delta b_{\mathrm{conv}}(q^*)$	λ_1 (yr^{-1})	λ_2 (yr^{-1})	E_{ceil}
0.60	+0.534	−0.0522	−0.975	0.804
0.85 (baseline)	+0.784	−0.0537	−0.998	1.138
1.20	+1.134	−0.0547	−1.014	1.606
2.00	+1.934	−0.0556	−1.029	2.675

(b) Initial demand P_0 at which $\min_t A_c$ approaches $A_c^{\min}$ to within:

A_{c0} (ha)	within 10^{-2}	within 10^{-4}	floor contact (10^{-6})
0.40	≈ 1.8	≈ 2.1	≈ 2.41
0.70	≈ 2.2	≈ 2.4	≈ 2.70
1.00	≈ 2.6	≈ 2.8	≈ 2.98
1.18	≈ 2.8	≈ 3.0	≈ 3.14

Proposition 3 (Boundedness asymmetry)**.** *Under* (12)–(14)*:*

(i) the technology factor satisfies $1 \le (b_{f0}+T_b(t))/b_{f0} \le 1+\Delta b/b_{f0}$ *for all* t*, so the logarithmic gain of the yield channel is bounded by* $\ln(1+\Delta b/b_{f0})$ *uniformly in time (*0.78 *at the baseline);*

(ii) the debt satisfies $D(t) \le \max\{D(0),\ \sup_{s\le t}[E-B]_+(s)/\eta\}$*, and* $D \to S^*/\eta$ *whenever the shortfall settles at* S^**; the degradation factor* $e^{-\alpha D}$ *is therefore bounded below only through the sustained shortfall;*

(iii) the degradation loss exceeds the maximal technology gain once the sustained shortfall exceeds $S^\dagger = (\eta/\alpha)\ln(1+\Delta b/b_{f0})$*, equal to* $1.30\,\mathrm{gha\,yr^{-1}}$ *at the baseline.*

Under an additive degradation law $b_f = b_{f0} + T_b - \alpha D$ *the two channels enter symmetrically and (iii) reduces to a comparison of* Δb *with* αD^**; the asymmetry is a property of the multiplicative form.*

Proof. (i) is $0 \le T_b \le \Delta b$. (ii) From (13), $\dot D \le \bar S - \eta D$ with $\bar S = \sup_{s\le t}[E-B]_+$, so $D(t) \le \max\{D(0), \bar S/\eta\}$ by comparison; if $[E-B]_+ \to S^*$ then $D \to S^*/\eta$. (iii) compares $\alpha S^*/\eta$ with $\ln(1+\Delta b/b_{f0})$. □

The proposition corrects a tempting overstatement: debt does not compound without bound under a fixed shortfall – it saturates at S^*/η – but its ceiling is set by the shortfall rather than by a parameter, and the shortfall is itself raised by demand growth. At the baseline the crossover shortfall $S^\dagger \approx 1.3\,\mathrm{gha\,yr^{-1}}$ exceeds the baseline biocapacity, so at these parameters the debt channel is a slow erosion rather than a reckoning; what bounds the mask at the baseline is the balance-point mechanism of Proposition 1(ii), with debt erosion as the second, slower limit. A second coupling works in the same direction: because $K = B/e$, any technology-driven rise in B raises the carrying capacity and, with the demographic delay, demand; under overshoot the wave that lifts the aggregate also raises the shortfall that feeds D – a Jevons-type rebound in which technology increases cumulative debt. The mask therefore opens only while the yield gain outpaces the debt build-up, and it is a transient diagnostic, not a new equilibrium.

3.4. Recovery requires an explicit, gated restoration flow

The model is structurally asymmetric: $A_c \to A_f$ proceeds through conversion, but no term in (6)–(8) returns land to the capital book except the

restoration flow R_{rc}. Fast-land retirement sends land to the reserve, not to capital. Reducing population, footprint or shortfall therefore does not reverse prior conversion: with $\chi_r = 0$ the capital book stays where the shortfall left it. In the endogenous-demand run with $A_{c0} = 1.0$ and $P_0 = 2.0$, capital land falls to 0.398 ha within four years and remains there without restoration, whereas with the surplus-gated flow ($\chi_r = 0.10$) it recovers to 0.828 ha, a recovery fraction $\mathcal{R}_c = (A_c(T) - A_c^{\mathrm{deg}})/(A_c^{\mathrm{init}} - A_c^{\mathrm{deg}}) = 0.71$ (SI §S4.3). The sign of the gate matters. A surplus-gated flow, active when $B > E$, is the ecologically sign-correct rewilding: it retires land only when the system has spare capacity, but it is inert during the shortfall it must eventually address – which is why the drawdown thresholds of Table 2b do not depend on χ_r – and once a surplus opens it can over-restore while the supported population re-equilibrates downward, so a target-level stopping rule is needed for a clean $\mathcal{R}_c = 1$ (SI §S4.4). A deficit-gated flow, active when $E > B$, is the one gate that acts during the shortfall, but it retires productive land exactly when provision is short and can deepen the near-term deficit; at the tested rates conversion outpaces it, so it is necessary but insufficient and must be sized or capped. Neither gate is an unqualified good, and the gate-sign asymmetry is phase-dependent rather than a universal ranking.

3.5. Measured composition of aggregate biocapacity, 1961–2022

The identity $d\ln B = d\ln(B/P) + d\ln P$ applied to the NFA world series gives the aggregation face of the result (Fig. 2). Aggregate biocapacity rose +23.0% ($\Delta\ln B = +0.207$, $+0.339\%\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$); per-capita biocapacity fell −52.9% ($\Delta\ln(B/P) = -0.752$, $-1.23\%\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$); the per-capita footprint rose +16.9%; and the biocapacity ratio $R_B = E/B$ rose from 0.718 to 1.782, crossing 1 in 1971. Because the identity is exact (residual $< 10^{-16}$) the split is unambiguous: population contributed +0.959 (+464% of $\Delta\ln B$) and the per-capita term −0.752 (−364%). This is the extensive/intensive split, not a causal claim (biocapacity is computed from area and yield independently of P), and it is not yet the two-land composition mask: the same aggregate that hides a per-capita halving is the one that would hide a capital-land drawdown.

To advance past the aggregate we apply the observation operator of Section 2.3. With A_f from FAOSTAT cropland area and b_f from the normalised crop-yield index calibrated at 1961, the exact Divisia decomposition (15) attributes the +0.207 aggregate log-change to a yield channel +0.393, a

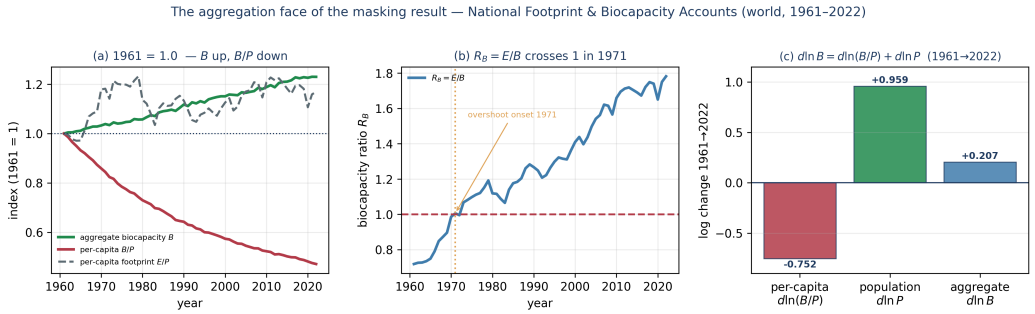


Figure 2: The aggregation face of the masking result, National Footprint and Biocapacity Accounts (world, 1961–2022). (a) Indices (1961 = 1) of aggregate biocapacity B, per-capita biocapacity B/P and per-capita footprint E/P: B rises while B/P halves. (b) The biocapacity ratio $R_B = E/B$ crosses 1 (overshoot onset) in 1971. (c) The exact identity $d\ln B = d\ln(B/P) + d\ln P$: population +0.959 and per-capita −0.752 (shares of $\Delta \ln B$: +464% and −364%). The public aggregate carries no yield/area split, so this panel is explicitly not the two-land composition mask.

cropland-area channel +0.056 and a residual −0.242 (Table 3). Raw component log-changes (+1.128, +0.160, −0.404) are changes in the components, not contributions, and cannot be summed; the log-mean weights $w_X = 0.349$, $w_C = 0.600$ make the identity exact, whereas average shares (0.375, 0.625) would give +0.231. The yield channel dominates the growth of the aggregate, cropland area is a small positive, and the residual – all biocapacity not captured by the cropland proxy – is a large negative. The result is robust to the unidentified base-year cropland share: over $\alpha \in [0.10, 0.34]$ the weighted identity sums to +0.207 exactly and the yield channel is the dominant positive term at every α, although the split is not pinned (w_X ranges 0.18–0.62); for $\alpha \geq 0.339$ the residual is no longer positive at the endpoint and the level decomposition $\Delta B = \Delta X + \Delta C$ (reproducing $\Delta B = +2.242 \times 10^9$ gha) carries the same sign statement (SI §S5.2). The nominal anchor $\alpha = 0.19$ can be replaced by the measured one, $b_f(1961) = B_{\text{cropland,NFA}}(1961)/A_f(1961) \approx 0.93\,\text{gha}\,\text{ha}^{-1}\,\text{yr}^{-1}$ (cropland share ≈ 0.128), which lies inside the robustness band and leaves the decomposition unchanged. The instantaneous fast-book share s_X rises from 0.19 to 0.56 over the period; only the growth and sign statements are robust, and b_c, $b_{G,c}$, ρ_c and the yield/area split of the residual remain unidentified, exactly as Proposition 1(iii) says they must.

The measured land-type accounts make the composition explicit without any proxy (Fig. 3). In the land-type vintage the aggregate grew +24.5%

Table 3: Exact log-mean (Divisia) decomposition of world aggregate biocapacity growth, 1961–2022 (NFA aggregate series; cropland proxies from FAOSTAT; base-year calibration $\alpha = 0.19$). Contributions sum exactly to $\Delta \ln B = +0.207$. Raw log-changes are component changes, not contributions.

Component	Raw $\Delta \ln$	Log-mean weight	Contribution to $\Delta \ln B$
Fast-book yield b_f (crop-yield index)	+1.128	$w_X = 0.349$	+0.393
Fast-book area A_f (cropland)	+0.160	$w_X = 0.349$	+0.056
Residual $C = B - b_f A_f$ (non-cropland)	−0.404	$w_C = 0.600$	−0.242
Total			+0.207

($\Delta \ln B = +0.219$), of which cropland contributed +23.8 points and built-up land +7.3 points, while forest products, grazing land and fishing grounds together contributed −6.6 points; the component ratios are cropland 2.85× (area 1.17×, per-hectare yield 2.43×), built-up 8.63×, forest products 0.90×, grazing 0.98×, fishing 0.96×. Cropland accounts for essentially all of the net aggregate growth (≈ 97–103% depending on vintage), and the non-cropland book is flat at the endpoint (1.008×; intra-period index up to 1.024×). The identifiability limit is recursive: the near-flat non-cropland total is itself the net of declining forest-products, grazing and fishing biocapacity (together $\approx -6.4 \times 10^8$ gha) and an 8.6× rise in built-up land. These categories are accounting flows and land classes rather than the model's capital stock, so the accounts do not demonstrate a measured decline in A_c; they do demonstrate that aggregate summary statistics conceal composition at more than one level.

3.6. Falsifiable predictions

The model's testable content, framed against two-book series (B, A_c, A_f and land-cover/yield proxies) rather than the aggregate, is the following.

P1. **Mask signature.** During conversion $\dot{A}_c < 0$ while $\dot{B} \geq 0$, and $R_B \leq 1$ is not required: the capital book can fall while the aggregate is at or below demand. Observing $\dot{A}_c < 0$ with a steady or rising B (composition mask) versus a steady E (liquidation mask) discriminates the two readings (Proposition 1).

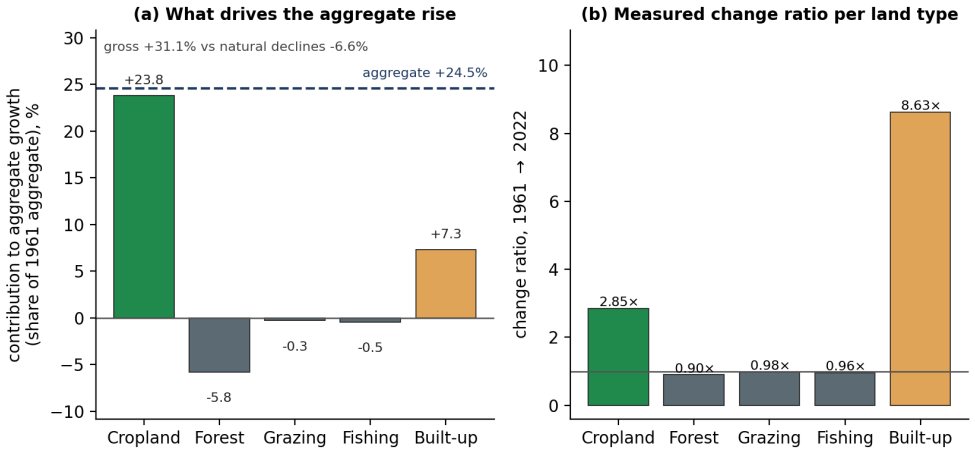


Figure 3: Measured land-type composition of aggregate biocapacity change, National Footprint and Biocapacity Accounts (world, 1961–2022, land-type vintage). (a) Contributions to the +24.5% aggregate growth ($\Delta \ln B = +0.219$): cropland +23.8 points and built-up land +7.3 points (gross +31.1), against forest products, grazing and fishing −6.6 points; the components sum exactly to the aggregate. (b) Endpoint ratios: cropland 2.85×, built-up 8.63×, forest products 0.90×, grazing 0.98×, fishing 0.96×. A single aggregate number cannot reveal this composition.

P2. **Window scale.** The duration of the mask is set by the slow eigenvalue λ_1 (through τ_{conv}, μ, η_f, b_c/b_f) and its amplitude by Δb_{conv} and the deficit, not by a fixed horizon; the bulk of conversion precedes the closing of the deficit by one to two e-folding times.

P3. **No critical-slowing precursor.** The return time does not grow as demand approaches the ceiling, and the drawdown depth is continuous in demand (Fig. 1c); the observable warning is the capital book approaching its typed floor (Proposition 2). This is a negative prediction: a catastrophic-shift early-warning indicator is not expected to precede the two-land drawdown.

P4. **Demand threshold, not delay threshold.** The initial demand that drives the capital book to its floor rises with initial capital (Table 2b) and is insensitive to the regeneration delay (identical to 10^{-3} for $\tau_g =$ 5–40 yr), because the regenerative share of capital value is small and quality is monotone; a one-stock regeneration cliff is not expected.

P5. **Recovery requires a gated flow.** Reducing demand does not restore

the capital book; recovery requires an explicit restoration flow whose gate sign determines whether it is inert during the shortfall (surplus-gated; thresholds unchanged by χ_r) or deepens it (deficit-gated).

The identifiability statement of Proposition 1(iii) is not a prediction but a constraint on testing: P1–P5 can be tested only with independent A_c and b_f proxies, never with the aggregate alone.

4. Discussion

4.1. What the two-land structure changes, and what it removes

The results depart from the single-stock, single-aggregate reading of the environment that dominates the resource and sustainability literature (Schaefer, 1954; May, 1973; Meadows et al., 1972, 2004; Wackernagel and Rees, 1996; Brander and Taylor, 1998) in three respects, each of which is a negative result as much as a positive one. First, the aggregate can rise while the capital book falls, but only as a bounded composition effect: Proposition 1 gives the exact condition and Proposition 3 the reason it cannot persist. Second, the capital drawdown is a demand-driven floor collision. The alternative-stable-states literature (Scheffer et al., 2001) predicts that a system approaching a fold shows critical slowing down, hysteresis and a discontinuous jump; none of these is present here, and their absence is structural (Table 4): the deficit-side dynamics are affine with constant real eigenvalues, the equilibrium leaves the admissible set through a face rather than through a bifurcation, and the drawdown depth is continuous in demand. Third, recovery is not the reverse of degradation; it requires an explicit, gated flow, and the gate sign is a design decision with phase-dependent consequences.

The negative results have a direct bearing on early-warning practice. Generic indicators of critical slowing down (rising autocorrelation and variance) are motivated by the approach to a fold (Scheffer et al., 2001). In a two-book system in which the drawdown is a boundary collision, such indicators would not be expected to fire, and their silence should not be read as safety. The informative signal is the capital book itself, which requires the two-book series.

Several quantities that circulate for models of this kind are deliberately not claimed here. The two-gain Hopf classification of which delay destabilises, the associated critical delays, and the reference eigenvalue of order $+0.6$ belong to a single-stock fast–slow reduction that we retain only as a

Table 4: Structural properties and negative results in the two-land model, each derived under the two-land structure rather than inherited from a one-stock comparator.

Phenomenon	Present?	Status in the two-land model
Capital-land catastrophic fold	No	$B_{eq}(A_c)$ is strictly monotone; the balance point is unique; the transition is a typed-floor collision at $E_{\text{ceil}} \approx 1.138$ (Proposition 2)
Critical slowing down	No	deficit-side dynamics are affine; $\lambda_1 \approx -0.054\,\text{yr}^{-1}$ is constant along the branch and does not tend to 0
Hysteresis / path dependence of the balance point	No	no second branch; irreversibility of the *area* book is a different property (no return flow without R_{rc}, Section 3.4)
Discontinuous collapse in demand	No	drawdown depth is continuous and monotone in P_0 (Fig. 1c); thresholds are tolerance-dependent bands
Regeneration-delay cliff	No	floor-contact threshold identical to 10^{-3} for $\tau_g = 5$–$40\,\text{yr}$; the regenerative share of capital value is small and q is monotone
Sustained boom–bust cycle	No	single overshoot pulse; q is monotone; $r\tau_p = 0.5 < \pi/2$, below the Hutchinson threshold of the delayed logistic population loop (Hutchinson, 1948)
Allee-type rescue threshold in capital	No	no capital level below which recovery is impossible other than the floor itself; the lever is demand or restoration, not the lag

comparator in SI §S7, where its equations, equilibrium family and figures are given; none of its features is carried into the two-land results. The "18–20 yr regeneration cliff" of the one-stock comparator does not survive the two-land structure (Table 4). What is structural in the two-land model is the composition logic and the identifiability limit; what is conditional on effective parameters is the sign and size of Δb_{conv} and the location of the ceiling.

4.2. Measurement implications

The methodological result of the paper is the identifiability limit. Biocapacity in global hectares is a value-weighted scalar, not a count of the underlying assets. Given only that a portfolio's value rose by 20%, one cannot tell whether every holding grew a little or some made large gains while others quietly fell; the scalar gloss hides the composition. This is the generic limit of any value-weighted composite (Nardo et al., 2008), and Proposition 1(iii) states it for biocapacity: the aggregate identifies one linear combination of the areas, and the capital-book parameters enter only through identifiable combinations. The aggregate is therefore a weak-sustainability index in the precise sense of the companion assessment work (Abaee, 2026b): it is the linear, perfectly substitutable member of the aggregator family (its Lemma A), and it can satisfy an aggregate floor while the typed floor on A_c is violated by exactly the amount that the fast-land yield gains against the capital loss. In that family no positive-elasticity aggregator is uniformly safe and only the typed, non-compensating one is (its Theorem S2(ii)). Under exact-tube semantics, in which a transition is safe only if every state along it satisfies the constraints, the passage during which A_c falls is itself a violation even if the endpoint recovers – a reason to report through-time trajectories and boundary curves, not endpoint attractors.

For the National Footprint Accounts the implication is concrete. The accounts are account-based and do not capture soil erosion, deforestation, groundwater depletion or other cumulative degradation, so estimated biocapacity likely overstates the real base and the footprint understates the overshoot (Wackernagel et al., 2002; Borucke et al., 2013); critics have made the point forcefully (Blomqvist et al., 2013; Giampietro and Saltelli, 2014; Galli et al., 2016; van den Bergh and Grazi, 2015). The present results add a different and more specific point: even an internally consistent aggregate cannot be inverted into its components. A growth headline for total biocapacity carries no information about whether cropland growth is compensating for stagnation or offsetting declines elsewhere, and the measured accounts show

that this is exactly what happened in 1961–2022 (Fig. 3). The informative assessment reports components with the total – at minimum component endpoint ratios, log contributions, attribution shares, data vintage and endpoint sensitivity – at every level at which an aggregate is used. Parallel observations have been made for human appropriation of net primary production and for land-management data (Haberl et al., 2007; Krausmann et al., 2013; Erb et al., 2017; Carvalhais et al., 2014): the composition of a flow aggregate, not its level, carries the sustainability information.

The empirical programme that follows is a flux reconstruction, not a curve fit. The observation operator of Section 2.3 is a hierarchy: NFA land-type biocapacity with physical area and yield factors where obtainable; FAOSTAT area and yields as independent external proxies (used here); remote-sensing land cover and historical reconstructions for validation and extension (SI §S5.4). Forest area is a sentinel proxy for A_c, not the whole capital book; capital-land regeneration is unobserved in the accounts and would require growing-stock or net-annual-increment data. The proxies do not solve global-hectare identifiability; they make the composition mechanism an independently anchored, falsifiable statement rather than an asserted one.

4.3. Policy operators

Three operators follow from the typed-floor structure and are developed in SI §S6. Freezing conversion – capping A_f or flooring A_c – is the single operator that guarantees $A_c \geq A_c^{\min}$; a governor that observes only the composite B cannot guarantee a capital-land floor, and the failure is informational rather than dynamical. Restoration is protective only when surplus-gated, and a deficit-gated flow can deepen the shortfall it is meant to relieve; this is the protective, as opposed to mobilising, institutional signature of the delay companion (Abaee, 2026a). A Half-Earth reservation (Wilson, 2016), $E \leq \sigma B$ with $\sigma < 1$, succeeds without liquidation on the nominal path, but this is a nominal-path consequence until it is certified against a declared disturbance class under a preregistered retention rule, and we state it as such.

4.4. Relation to companion work

The accounting layer – the closed typed-flux ledger, conservation and donor-limitation rules, depletion arithmetic and the no-non-negative-weighting aggregation obstruction – is the object of the ledger companion (Abaee, 2026c), which owns the static layer, cedes delay dynamics to its companions and registers a two-pool dynamical model as an open gap; the

present paper supplies that minimal dynamical realisation for the global-hectare case. The aggregation theorem that places B at the weak extreme of the aggregator family is from the assessment companion (Abaee, 2026b), and the institutional-delay regime is from the governance companion (Abaee, 2026a); the delays here are ecological (regeneration, demography), not institutional. We cite, and do not re-derive, those results.

4.5. Limitations

The capital land is an effective class, not a single land type; the single regeneration timescale, the composition diagnostic and the ceiling are effective-parameter statements, and the full vector decomposition is cited rather than re-derived. Most parameters are representative rather than estimated; b_c, $b_{G,c}$ and ρ_c are not identifiable from a cross-section, and the regeneration anchors bound a band rather than calibrate ρ_c (the anchors concern the regeneration rate, not the lag τ_g). The per-capita footprint is held constant to isolate the stock–flow–demand feedbacks; endogenising e is an extension. The composition window is bounded and demand-driven; without a sustained shortfall or a technology/demand feedback it closes at the balance point. Stability at $S = 0$ is one-sided because the positive part is exact. Drawdown thresholds are tolerance-dependent bands; a small margin next to that band is reported as such and not as a sharp boundary. The debt-repayment rate is set physical and non-singular ($\eta = 0.05\,\mathrm{yr}^{-1}$); the $\eta \to 0$ case removes the debt equilibrium and is excluded by a floor, and outcomes are insensitive to η over a modest positive range. The accounts do not separate yield from area, which is the identifiability limitation the paper is about rather than an estimation error. Finally, the delayed-regeneration term is implemented at the current quality in the deposited solver (Section 2.4); we have verified that applying the delay changes no reported quantity by more than 1%, and the corrected variant is deposited alongside.

5. Conclusions

A single aggregate of annual bioproductive supply can conceal the composition of what is growing, and the concealment is structural. In a minimal two-land model with conserved area, a separate quality state and demand-driven conversion, the aggregate rises while the ecological-capital book falls whenever the fast-land yield exceeds the per-hectare value of capital land (Proposition 1); from the aggregate alone the capital loss is unidentified, and

independent fast-book proxies identify at most a measured fast book and a residual. The drawdown of the capital book under sustained demand is a floor collision at a demand ceiling, not a catastrophic shift: the deficit-side dynamics are affine, the leading eigenvalue is constant along the branch, there is no fold, no hysteresis and no critical slowing down, and the drawdown depth is a continuous function of demand (Proposition 2). The mask is bounded because technology lifts the fast yield by at most a fixed factor whereas debt erosion is limited only by the sustained shortfall (Proposition 3), and recovery requires an explicit restoration flow whose gate sign matters. In the measured National Footprint and Biocapacity Accounts for 1961–2022, aggregate biocapacity grew 23% while per-capita biocapacity halved, the exact Divisia decomposition attributes the growth to cropland yield with a negative non-cropland residual, and the land-type accounts show cropland biocapacity growing 2.85× against a flat non-cropland book that is itself the net of declining forest, grazing and fishing biocapacity and rising built-up land. These results establish an identifiability property of aggregate biocapacity and a measured composition pattern; they are not a forecast and do not show a measured decline in the model's ecological-capital stock. Their practical content is a reporting rule: an aggregate biocapacity total is informative only when its components are reported alongside it, at every level at which the aggregate is used. A modern economy can run for decades on a harvest that looks healthy while the orchard behind it quietly shrinks; the harvest number will not say so, and only the two-book series can.

Declarations

Data availability. Code and data are available at https://zenodo.org/records/22554480. This study reports no new empirical dataset; the empirical inputs are published values (NFA 2025 edition, FAOSTAT) used to bound the regeneration timescale and to decompose the composition of aggregate biocapacity. The scripts that regenerate Fig. 1 and Table 2 from the deposited model code accompany the Supplementary Information.

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